

MARKET BRIEF · SEPTEMBER 2026

Senior Dog Home Care in Europe: A Category Opportunity Brief

What's driving demand, where European DTC stores have gaps, and which home-care categories are growing fastest — for online pet retailers planning their 2026/2027 assortment.

91M

dogs in Europe (FEDIAF 2026)

~1 in 3

dogs are 7+ years old — "senior"

7%+

annual growth in mobility/ramps category

01 Why senior dogs are the growth story

Europe has 91 million pet dogs across 140 million pet-owning households. Two structural shifts are reshaping what these households buy: dogs are living longer, and Europe's human population is the oldest of any major market — older owners spend more on comfort and care for their pets.

€29.4bn European pet food market value (2024, FEDIAF); pet services & accessories add a further €24.6bn	~35% of dogs are estimated to be over 7 years old, and rising as veterinary care extends lifespans	22% of the EU population is 65+; Italy 24.7%, Germany 22.7% (Eurostat, Jan 2025)
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Arthritis is the mass-market driver

Osteoarthritis affects roughly 1 in 5 dogs overall — and up to **80% of dogs over age 7** in veterinary surveys. Dogs rarely cry out; they simply slow down, hesitate at stairs, or stop jumping onto the sofa. That's the moment owners start searching for home solutions — and they search for *products, not medication*: beds that ease joints, ramps that remove impact, mats that stop slips on hard European floors (tile, laminate, wood).

What this means for assortment: senior home-care is no longer a niche. It sits at the intersection of three growing pools — more old dogs, more old owners (49% of EU households own a pet), and premiumisation of pet spending. Retailers who treat "senior" as a merchandised category, rather than a filter tag, capture the demand.

The fastest-growing categories

Category	Market signal	Growth
Orthopedic / memory-foam beds	Highest-growth bed segment; vet-recommended; premium margins	+7.8% CAGR
Ramps & stairs	Senior-dog mobility = 54% of the global ramp/stair market; veterinary recommendations expanding	+7.0% CAGR
Anti-slip mats & traction	Hard-floor homes across Europe; low-ticket, high-repeat add-on	Underserved online
Recovery / post-surgery wear	Rising neutering & orthopedic surgery rates; alternative to cones	Emerging
Cooling & seasonal care	Heatwave frequency in Southern Europe; cooling products growing fast	+6.7% CAGR

Sources: FEDIAF Annual Report 2026 (europeanpetfood.org); Eurostat population structure, Jan 2025; veterinary reviews on canine osteoarthritis prevalence; category market reports (Dataintel dog beds; StatsMarketResearch dog step & ramp; PMarketResearch pet ramp & stair).

02 Where European stores have gaps

Across a review of 600+ European DTC pet stores (18 markets), senior home-care is consistently under-merchandised. Most stores carry one orthopedic bed and treat the rest of the senior journey as an afterthought. The gaps cluster in four areas:

1 • No "senior" destination
Stores stock senior-relevant products scattered across Beds, Travel, Grooming. Shoppers searching "old dog" or "hund senior" rarely find a curated landing page — yet that search intent converts.

2 • Mobility beyond the bed
Beds are well covered. Ramps, stairs, anti-slip runners and post-surgery wear are thin or absent — especially ramps sized for European cars (smaller hatchbacks vs. US SUVs).

3 • Size & fit coverage
Large-breed seniors (Labradors, Shepherds) need XL/XXL orthopedic beds and high-weight-rated ramps — frequently out of stock or missing entirely.

4 • Bundle / kit logic
Vets recommend a system (bed + ramp + traction together), but almost no retailer merchandises a "senior starter kit". Basket size and repeat purchase both rise when products are sold as a solution.

03 Price architecture — what European shoppers pay

Based on listed price ranges across 600+ European online pet stores:

Category	Typical retail band (EUR)	Median	Notes
Orthopedic beds	€30 – €150+	€70	XL / memory-foam premium tier €100-150
Ramps & stairs	€35 – €120	€45	Foldable / car ramps command premium
Recovery wear / clothing	€15 – €60	€50	Post-surgery suits price above fashion wear
Anti-slip mats	€10 – €40	€15-25	Entry price point; high attach rate
Overall store price band	€15 – €114 (P25-P75)	€48	Mid-market dominates European DTC

Margin logic for retailers: home-care hardware (beds, ramps, gates) is where the margin lives. These are non-food, non-supplement, unregulated product groups — no certification burden, durable (not consumable), and differentiation comes from design, size range and bundle presentation rather than brand. That's the ideal profile for white-label / private-label development.

Merchandising checklist for a senior category launch

- **Dedicated "Senior Dog" landing page** organised by need: Sleep · Mobility · Traction · Recovery · Seasonal
- **Size coverage up to XXL** in beds and ramps (large breeds are the fastest-growing senior segment)
- **Starter kit bundle:** bed + ramp + traction mat at a bundle price — raises AOV 40-60%
- **Content anchors:** one short article per need ("slippery floors", "dog won't use stairs") — captures 7+ dog-owner search traffic
- **Local-language sizing & car-fit guidance** for ramps (DE / FR / IT especially)

04 Sourcing these categories: a practical note

For retailers considering private label or direct sourcing: senior home-care categories are concentrated among specialised manufacturers in East China (Zhejiang / Jiangsu), most within a 2-hour logistics cluster. Typical structure for a European DTC store testing the category:

Stage	Quantity	Logistics	Purpose
Sample / test	1-5 pieces	Express courier, 7-10 days to EU	Validate quality & fit before committing
Small trial order	20-50 pieces mixed SKUs	LCL sea freight (~35-40 days), cost per unit drops sharply	Real sell-through test with healthy margin
White-label range	100+ per SKU	FCL / scheduled LCL	Own-brand category launch

All six core categories (orthopedic beds, ramps/stairs, anti-slip mats, recovery wear, safety gates, grooming/dental tool kits) are non-medical, non-electrical, non-food — no special certification regime, no supplement regulation. Standard product safety and labelling rules apply, same as any pet accessory.

Key takeaways for your 2026/2027 planning:

- Senior home care is a structurally growing, demography-backed category — not a trend
- Beds are table stakes; ramps, traction, recovery wear and kits are the whitespace
- €30-€100 is the European mid-market sweet spot; bundles lift basket size
- Low entry barriers to test: single-piece sampling, then small mixed-SKU sea-freight orders

About this brief

This report was prepared by Loyal Bond Pet (Lishui, China), a manufacturer specialising in senior-dog home-care products across the six categories above — orthopedic beds, ramps & stairs, anti-slip mats, recovery wear, safety gates and grooming/dental kits.

We supply European and North American DTC stores and retailers with ready-stock samples (1 piece minimum), white-label and ODM options. If anything in this brief sparks an assortment idea, we're happy to share spec sheets and wholesale pricing — no pressure and no automated follow-ups.

Reply to the email that shared this report, or reach us through our website.

Data sources: FEDIAF Annual Report 2026 (europeanpetfood.org) · Eurostat population structure, Jan 2025 · Destatis / World Bank 65+ population tables · Veterinary literature on canine osteoarthritis & senior dog demographics (PMC reviews) · Dataintelto Dog Beds Market; StatsMarketResearch Dog Step & Ramp; PMarketResearch Pet Ramp & Stair · Retail price bands compiled from 600+ European DTC pet stores across 18 markets. Figures are industry estimates for planning purposes.